paucity of textual and material traces of these populations through time. The available data indicate nonetheless that their coalescence as an economically and then politically dominant regional presence was largely based on increasing interactions with the mercantile communities throughout their circuits of transhumance. Surely underpinning their ascendancy was the generation of surplus resources, even while engaging in seasonal migrations and pastoralism. During the eleventh and twelfth centuries – and likely before – the ancestors of the Shansabanis had been exposed to Islamic proselytism by variably heterodox groups such as the Karramiyya, and quite likely Sufis and other spiritualists as well. But by the mid-twelfth century, it was arguably the public acknowledgment and practice of an overtly orthodox Islam that ultimately resulted in their emergence as a regional and then transregional power, as well as the historical retrievability of this process. The patronage of skilled labor to construct the recently rediscovered Da Qadi *minar* encapsulated the Shansabanis' twofold transformation: regional politico-economic dominance and the concomitant proclamation of an Islam-affiliated identity.

Subsequently, Chapter 3 traced the growing bifurcation in lifestyles of the nominally senior or principal Shansabanis based at Firuzkuh, and their agnates at Bamiyan, further highlighting the rapid – even alacritous – adaptation of these two increasingly independent branches to their respective contexts. Despite Firuzkuh's albeit tangential location within the commercial networks radiating throughout Khurasan – networks that also interwove Khurasan's urban–intellectual centers – the Firuzkuh Shansabanis appear to have remained tent-dwelling and continued their seasonal migrations, essentially utilizing Firuzkuh as their *sard-sir* encampment or summer "capital." The most recent archaeological work at the site (2003–2005) revealed patronage of public structures, such as the more famous *minar* and its adjacent mosque(s), rather than palaces. It was the Shansabani branch at Bamiyan who exhibited palace-building and dwelling, and perhaps increasing sedentism over time, as evidenced by archaeological surveys at Shahr-i Zuhak and Shahr-i Ghulghula in the Bamiyan valley. This change of lifeways surely occurred in response to localized requirements for the exercise and performance of kingship, entrenched in the Bamiyan region's cultural history.

As seen in Chapter 4, well before their declared espousal of the Shafi'iyya in AH 595/1199 CE, the Firuzkuh Shansabani elites had already outgrown their exclusive loyalty to the Karramiyya: they extended their contacts with the more orthodox – and politically and economically more powerful – Khurasani *madhhab*s. The magnificent Shah-i Mashhad *madrasa* (AH 560s/1165–1175 CE) demonstrated not only the Shansabanis' emulation of their Ghaznavid predecessors in its epigraphic program, the large and lavishly inscribed complex also hinted at their acuity in diversifying patronage among the prominent legal–theological schools of